St. James's Place: the business and the role

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Labels used throughout:

- **PRIMARY**: from SJP's own filings, mostly the FY2025 results.
- **REPORTED**: from reputable press.
- **UNVERIFIED**: from one source, or from my general knowledge.
- **[Interpretation]**: my own reasoning.

This pack goes with the longer *SJP Interview Deep Dive*. That covers fees, the controversy, competitors and share price. This pack covers how the firm works, and what the job is.

PART A: THE BUSINESS

A1. SJP in one page

One sentence: SJP is a **financial advice business that also owns the products and funds its advisers recommend**. It makes money by charging an annual percentage on every pound its clients invest with it.

Funds under management (FUM)	**£240.8bn** at 30 June 2026 (PRIMARY); £242.4bn at 30 Sept 2026 (REPORTED)
Clients	**1,064,000** (PRIMARY, H1 2026)
Advisers	**4,951**, almost all self-employed **"Partners"** (PRIMARY, H1 2026)
Average money per client	**~£226k** (derived: FUM ÷ clients)
Average money per adviser	**~£48.6m** across **~215 clients** (derived)
Profit (Underlying cash result, 2025)	**£462.3m** after tax (PRIMARY)
Leadership	Group CEO **Mark FitzPatrick**; CFO **Caroline Waddington**; Chair **Paul Manduca** (PRIMARY). CEO of SJP Wealth Management **James Rainbow**, ex-Schroders, appointed 2025 (REPORTED). CEO, Investments **Justin Onuekwusi** (REPORTED)
Head office	Cirencester. London office: Lombard Street, where your role is based

The mental model [Interpretation]: think of SJP as two businesses bolted together.

1. **A distribution business.** It finds clients and keeps them, through ~5,000 advisers who build personal, long-term relationships.
2. **A manufacturing business.** It owns the "products" those clients invest through (pensions, ISAs, bonds) and the funds inside them.

The **advice** is what the client thinks they are buying. Most of SJP's **profit** comes from the **annual charges on the products and funds** that hold the client's money.

A2. What SJP sells

The products: where the money actually sits

Every client pound sits in a **"wrapper"**, a tax structure, and inside that in **funds**. SJP owns both layers.

Product (wrapper)	What it is, in plain English	FUM at end-2025	Share of FUM	2025 gross inflows	Share of new money
Pensions (personal pensions, SIPPs, drawdown)	Retirement savings with tax relief going in. Money is locked until age 55 (57 from 2028), then drawn as income.	**£119.9bn**	**55%**	**£13.9bn**	**63%**

Product (wrapper)	What it is, in plain English	FUM at end-2025	Share of FUM	2025 gross inflows	Share of new money
Investment bonds	An insurance-based wrapper, popular for tax planning: deferring tax, trusts, inheritance planning. Mostly used by wealthier clients.	£44.1bn	20%	£3.0bn	14%
Unit trusts / ISAs and DFM	ISAs: up to £20k a year invested tax-free. Unit trusts: ordinary taxable investment accounts. DFM (discretionary fund management) is a bespoke portfolio run by a manager.	£56.0bn (incl. DFM £3.7bn)	25%	£5.0bn	23%

All figures PRIMARY (FY2025 results). Shares of the total are derived from them. SJP's Asia and Middle East business (SJP AME) is included above, at £2.3bn of FUM (PRIMARY).

Pensions are the engine. They are over half the money and nearly two-thirds of new money. Why, **[Interpretation]**:

1. **Pension freedoms (2015).** Retirees no longer have to buy an annuity, a guaranteed income for life bought from an insurer. Instead they can keep their pension invested and draw income from it ("drawdown"). That requires ongoing investment decisions, which is exactly where advice is valuable.
2. **Consolidation.** People build up many small workplace pensions over a career. Bringing them together into one plan is a common, high-value piece of advice.
3. **Tax.** Pensions get income tax relief on contributions, and historically sat outside the estate for inheritance tax (IHT). That changes from **April 2027**, when unused pensions come into IHT (REPORTED). That change creates *more* need for advice.
4. **Stickiness.** Pension money stays for decades. The pension surrender rate was **4.0%** of FUM in 2025, against 7.4% for unit trusts and ISAs (PRIMARY).

The funds: what the money is invested in

- **SJP's own fund range:** SJP's investment team doesn't mainly pick shares itself. It **selects, hires and monitors external fund managers** to run SJP-branded funds, a "manager of managers" model (PRIMARY: "investment management fees paid to external fund managers").
- **Polaris:** the flagship multi-asset range, **£94bn** (PRIMARY, end-2025). It has four risk levels, so a client can be matched to their risk appetite.
- **Polaris Multi-Index:** a cheaper, index-based range launched in 2025, above £1bn of FUM (PRIMARY).
- **Where the money is invested** (end-2025, PRIMARY):
  - 38% North American equities
  - 17% bonds (fixed income)
  - 14% European equities
  - 14% Asia-Pacific equities
  - 9% UK equities
  - the rest in cash, alternatives and property

The services: what the adviser actually does

The client experiences this as **"advice"**, which covers:

- **Retirement planning:** how much you need, when you can stop work, and how to draw income tax-efficiently.
- **Investment planning:** using ISA and pension allowances, and matching risk to goals.
- **Inheritance and estate planning:** gifts, trusts, IHT.
- **Protection:** life cover, critical illness and income protection (REPORTED, SJP website).
- **Business owners and professionals:** extracting profits, exit planning, workplace financial education (REPORTED, SJP website).
- **Mortgages and wills:** offered through **separate firms**, and described by SJP as "separate and distinct" services. Wills are not FCA-regulated (REPORTED, SJP website).

Why SJP sells this mix [Interpretation]:

- **It makes the client "whole of life".** One relationship covers pensions, savings, protection, inheritance and the next generation, which raises retention.
- **Advice is the front door.** Every plan ends in SJP products. That is the commercial logic of vertical integration (owning several stages of what the client pays for), and also the source of the "restricted advice" conflict.
- **The client's family is the long-term prize.** Estate planning brings the next generation in before wealth passes down.

A3. Who the target clients are, and why

The profile [Interpretation, built on PRIMARY averages]

- **Wealth:** "mass affluent" to "high net worth" (HNW). Typically £100k to a few million to invest, with an average of ~£226k per client with SJP.
- **Life stage:** mainly **45 to 70+**. Pre-retirees and retirees, because pensions are 55% of FUM and retirement decisions trigger the need for advice.
- **Occupation:**
  - **business owners** (exit and profit-extraction planning);
  - **professionals** such as doctors, lawyers and senior employees. SJP runs propositions aimed at NHS staff and law society members (REPORTED, SJP website);
  - **families** planning to pass on wealth.
- **How they arrive:** mostly by **referral**, from existing clients, accountants and solicitors. That's cheap, trusted, and suits a relationship business.

Why these clients and not others [Interpretation]

Segment	Why SJP does or doesn't target it
Mass market (under ~£50k)	Too small. A percentage fee on £30k doesn't pay for an adviser's time. These people are served by platforms such as AJ Bell, robo-advisers, and now the FCA's **targeted support** regime (live April 2026). Targeted support lets firms give semi-personalised suggestions without full advice.
Affluent and HNW (£100k to £5m)	**The sweet spot.** Enough money that fees pay for real advice. Complex enough needs (pensions, tax, IHT, business exit) that advice clearly adds value. And people who value a personal relationship over the cheapest price.
UHNW (ultra-high net worth, conventionally US$30m+ net worth)	Mostly not SJP's market. These clients want private banking: lending, complex structures, bespoke portfolios, alternatives. They have the bargaining power to negotiate fees down. Coutts, JP Morgan Private Bank and UBS compete here.

The economics behind the sweet spot [Interpretation, derived]:

- **Advice fees per adviser:** the average adviser looks after ~£48.6m. At 0.8% a year, that book generates roughly **£390k a year in ongoing advice charges**. That is before practice costs (staff, offices) and any share SJP takes.
- **Why that's attractive:** it's what makes being a Partner attractive, and why the model can support ~5,000 advisers.
- **The trade-off:** a client with £20k would generate £160 a year, which can't pay for meaningful adviser time.

A4. What makes the most money

How SJP's profit is built (2025, PRIMARY)

SJP's own profit measure is the **Underlying cash result**. It strips out accounting items and one-offs such as the refund provision, and from 2026 is called "adjusted IFRS profit after tax".

Line	£m 2025	What it means
Net annual management fee	1,170.9	What SJP keeps from annual charges on FUM, **after** paying Partners' advice fees, external fund managers and the administrator
Less: reduction for "gestation"	(445.7)	Older pension and bond money in its first six years earned little product margin under the old charges
= Net income from FUM	**725.2**	**The core profit engine**
Margin from new business	99.5	Old-style initial charges minus new-business costs. **Expected to be ~£0 from 2026**, because the new initial advice charges mostly go to Partners
Shareholder interest	68.5	Interest earned on SJP's own cash
Controllable expenses	(305.8)	People, property, technology
Other items	(125.6)	Regulatory levies (FSCS, the compensation scheme funded by the industry), investment in DFM and AME, one-off costs of the charging change (£52.7m), and miscellaneous
= Underlying cash result	**462.3**	

The biggest revenue generator, by far: annual charges on FUM. They make up ~81% of the positive items in 2025, and **more than that from 2026**, when new-business margin drops to around zero (derived).

By product [Interpretation]: SJP doesn't publish profit by product. Pensions are 55% of FUM and most of the new money, so they are almost certainly the largest single source of profit. They will grow more profitable as the ~£53bn of "gestation" money (mostly pensions and bonds) matures into full charging by around 2031 (PRIMARY: £52.9bn in gestation at end-2025).

Who keeps what on a typical pound

For a client with £500k in an ISA in Polaris 3, paying **1.59% a year** (~£7,950):

Layer	Rate	£ a year	Goes mainly to
Ongoing advice	0.80%	£4,000	**The Partner** (SJP reportedly now keeps a share; the split isn't published)

Layer	Rate	£ a year	Goes mainly to
Product charge	0.27%	£1,350	**SJP** (it pays the administrator out of this)
Fund charge	0.52%	£2,600	Split between **SJP** and the **external fund managers**
SJP's net keep	~0.43–0.45% of mature FUM (PRIMARY guidance)	~£2,150–2,250	**SJP shareholders** (estimate)

Under the new charges (from 26 Aug 2025), the **initial advice charge** (3%/2%/1%, capped at £30k) mostly funds the Partner. SJP says initial charges "broadly offset" its new-business costs (PRIMARY).

The profit formula [Interpretation]

> **Profit ≈ FUM × net margin − largely fixed costs**

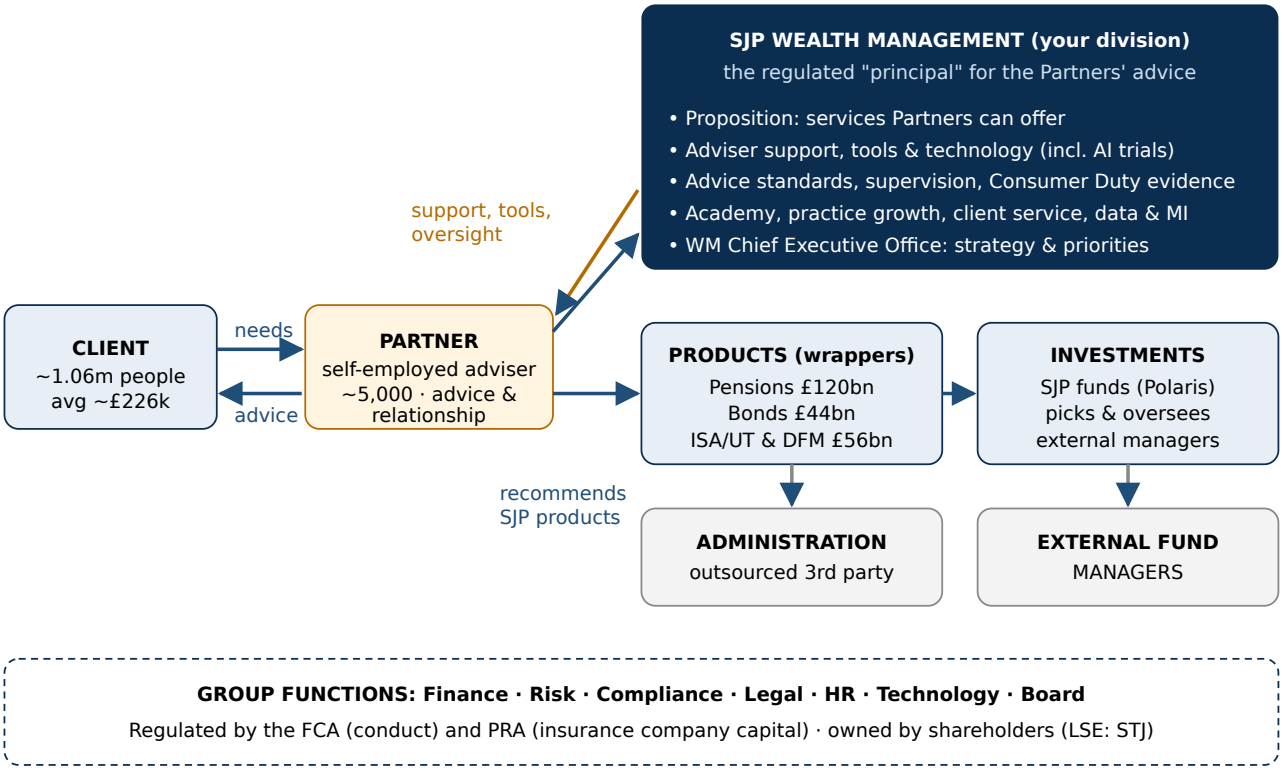
So four levers drive SJP's profit:

1. **Markets.** In 2025, investment returns added **£23.6bn** to FUM against only £6.2bn of net new money (PRIMARY). SJP's income rises and falls with stock markets.
    - Rough sensitivity: a 10% fall in FUM would cut net income from FUM by roughly £70m a year. That is about 15% of profit, because costs don't fall with markets. This is "operating leverage".
2. **Net flows:** new money in minus money out. Gross inflows were £21.9bn and net only £6.2bn in 2025 (PRIMARY), so retention matters as much as winning new clients.
3. **Margin:** cut by the 2025 charging change. It rebuilds as gestation money matures; management expects roughly +3bps a year to 2031 (REPORTED). A basis point (bp) is 0.01%.
4. **Costs:** a ~£100m-a-year cost reduction programme due by 2027 (PRIMARY).

Why this matters for your role: the head-office Wealth Management function mostly works on levers 2 and 4 (and protects the margin by keeping clients happy and compliant). See B4.

A5. How all the functions work together

The picture



Following one client through the business [Interpretation, based on how SJP describes its model]

1. **Referral.** A 58-year-old business owner is referred to a Partner by their accountant.
2. **Fact-find and advice.** The Partner gathers their finances and goals, builds a cashflow plan, and recommends consolidating three old pensions into an SJP pension invested in Polaris, plus annual ISA top-ups and an inheritance plan. The recommendation goes into a written **suitability report** explaining why it fits the client.
    - **Wealth Management** supplies the tools, templates, research and **advice-standards checks** behind this, because SJP is legally responsible for the advice.
3. **Implementation.** The money moves into an **SJP pension** (product). The **outsourced administrator** processes the paperwork. The money is invested in **Polaris**, which SJP's **Investments** team has handed to external fund managers to run.
4. **Charges.** The client pays the initial advice charge, which mostly goes to the Partner. Then every year they pay ongoing advice + product + fund charges, split as in A4.
5. **Ongoing service.** The Partner holds annual reviews.
    - **Wealth Management** helps make sure these happen *and are evidenced*. That is the lesson of the £426m refund provision.
    - Client service handles queries; data and MI (management information) teams monitor outcomes under **Consumer Duty**, the FCA rules requiring firms to deliver good outcomes and fair value.
6. **Retention and growth.** If the client is happy, they stay (~95% retention), add money, and introduce their children. FUM grows, and so does SJP's income.

7. **Group functions. Finance** reports results to shareholders; **Risk and Compliance** oversee conduct; the **Board** sets strategy (now moving from "Strengthen" to "Amplify" in 2027).

The flywheel [Interpretation]

> Better adviser tools and proposition → more productive, loyal Partners → better client outcomes and retention → more FUM → more income → reinvest in advisers and tools.

The Wealth Management division sits at the **start of the flywheel**. That's why a graduate there can affect the numbers that matter.

Built-in tensions to understand

- **Restricted advice vs client choice:** SJP's advisers recommend mainly SJP's own products. This is legal, but it's a permanent conflict of interest that has to be managed.
- **Partner independence vs SJP's control:** the Partners are entrepreneurs, but SJP is liable for their advice. Too much control drives Partners away; too little creates conduct risk.
- **Growth vs supervision:** more advisers means more oversight burden.
- **Price vs value:** under Consumer Duty, SJP must *prove* clients get fair value for ~1.6–1.7% a year.

PART B: THE ROLE

B1. What "wealth management" actually means

"Wealth management" is used loosely. It helps to separate the activities, because different firms do different combinations.

Activity	What it is	Example UK firms
Financial planning / advice	Understanding a person's whole financial life and recommending what to do: pensions, tax, protection, inheritance. Regulated; advisers need a **Level 4** qualification.	SJP, Quilter, IFA firms, Evelyn
Investment management (discretionary)	A manager runs a portfolio and makes the buy/sell decisions for the client.	Rathbones, Evelyn, Quilter Cheviot
Advisory / execution-only investing	The client makes the decisions, with or without suggestions.	Hargreaves Lansdown, AJ Bell (D2C platforms)
Private banking	Banking, lending and investment services for very wealthy clients.	Coutts, JP Morgan Private Bank, UBS
Family office	A dedicated team managing everything for one ultra-wealthy family.	Bespoke
Asset management	*Makes* funds and sells them to many investors. It serves the fund, not the individual client.	BlackRock, Schroders, M&G

The distinction to be crisp on:

- **Asset management** manufactures investment *products*.
- **Wealth management** serves *people*: it decides what a particular individual should do with their money and looks after them over time.
- **SJP is mainly a wealth manager** (advice-led), with an asset management *arm* that it largely outsources to external managers.
- Your understanding of asset-management fees is useful here: it's the "fund layer" of SJP's model.

What a financial planner actually does: the advice journey

1. **Discovery / fact-find.** Income, assets, debts, pensions, family, goals, attitude to risk, **capacity for loss** (how much the client could afford to lose without hurting their plans).
2. **Analysis. Cashflow modelling** projects their finances year by year to answer questions like "can I retire at 60?" and "how much can I gift?". It also involves tax analysis and reviewing existing pensions and investments.
3. **Recommendation.** A **suitability report** sets out what to do and *why it suits this client*. This is an FCA requirement.
4. **Implementation.** Opening pensions and ISAs, transferring money, choosing funds, arranging protection.
5. **Ongoing service.** Annual reviews: rebalancing, using new tax allowances, reacting to life events (retirement, inheritance, divorce, illness) and to tax changes. Evidence that the service happened is essential under **Consumer Duty**.

The regulatory basics you should know

Term	Meaning
FCA	Financial Conduct Authority, which regulates how firms treat customers
RDR (2013)	Retail Distribution Review. Banned commission on investment advice, required advisers to hold Level 4 qualifications, and created the "independent" vs "restricted" labels
Consumer Duty (2023)	Firms must deliver good outcomes and **fair value**, and be able to prove it
Suitability	Advice must fit the individual client's needs, objectives and risk profile
FOS	Financial Ombudsman Service, which settles customer complaints for free
FSCS	Financial Services Compensation Scheme, which compensates customers if a firm fails. Funded by an industry levy
Targeted support (Apr 2026)	A new FCA category between generic guidance and full advice, aimed at people who can't afford advice

B2. What this role actually is

The basics (from the job description)

- **Title:** Wealth Management Graduate Programme, London (Lombard Street), starting Sept 2027.
- **Contract:** permanent from day one. Two years of rotations, then you stay in the Wealth Management division.
- **Work pattern:** hybrid, with at least three office days a week and occasional UK travel.
- **Qualification:** support to achieve the **Level 4 Diploma in Regulated Financial Planning**.
- **What it is not:** this is **head office, not client-facing advice.** You won't be a Partner or join the Academy. Your "customers" are mainly the **Partners**, and through them the **clients**.

Where you'd sit

- **The company: SJP Wealth Management**, the part of SJP that acts as the regulated principal for the Partners' advice and supports them.
- **Its chief executive: James Rainbow** (REPORTED, appointed 2025 from Schroders).
- **The CEO Office:** the JD mentions projects in the **Wealth Management Chief Executive Office**. That is the team supporting the division's leadership on strategy, priorities, board and executive papers, and major programmes.

Likely rotation areas [Interpretation: the JD doesn't name the teams, so ask about them]

Likely team	What it does	Example graduate task (illustrative)
Proposition	Designs what Partners can offer clients: services, pricing, new solutions	Research how competitors package retirement income advice; help scope a service for clients affected by pensions entering IHT in 2027
Adviser / Partner experience and technology	Tools, systems and support that make Partners productive	Gather Partner feedback on an AI note-taking trial; measure time saved per client review
Data, MI and insight	Analyses flows, retention, productivity and outcomes	Build a dashboard showing which client segments drove the Q3 2026 rise in pension withdrawals

Likely team	What it does	Example graduate task (illustrative)
Advice standards / supervision	Makes sure advice is suitable and evidenced	Analyse review-completion rates; help design how ongoing reviews are evidenced (the lesson of the refund review)
Client experience / service	Client communications, complaints insight, journeys	Map the client journey for a pension consolidation and find the drop-off points
Partnership growth / Academy	Recruiting and developing advisers; practice growth	Analyse what distinguishes the fastest-growing Partner practices
WM Chief Executive Office	Strategy, planning, executive reporting	Draft slides for the leadership team on progress against "Amplify" priorities

Mapping the JD's verbs to real work

JD says	In practice
"Analyse data and produce insights"	Excel, possibly SQL or Power BI; turning numbers into "so what?"
"Prepare reports, presentations and communications … including senior leaders"	Clear slides and short papers with a recommendation up front
"Contribute to projects that enhance the adviser and client experience"	Programme work, with you as a junior team member
"Build relationships … across the business"	Working with Partners, compliance, investments, technology
"Level 4 Diploma"	Studying for exams alongside work

The Level 4 Diploma

- **What it is:** the qualification standard the FCA requires before someone can give retail investment advice, set by the RDR.
- **Which diploma:** commonly the **CII Diploma in Regulated Financial Planning (DipPFS)**. It is usually six units covering:
    - financial services, regulation and ethics;
    - investment principles and risk;
    - personal taxation;
    - pensions and retirement planning;
    - financial protection;
    - financial planning practice.

  (UNVERIFIED that SJP uses the CII route; the JD just says "Level 4 Diploma". Ask.)
- **Why it matters for you:** it gives you an adviser's technical toolkit while you work in head office. You'll understand what Partners actually do, which makes your projects better.
- **Careful framing:** it also keeps future options open. Don't pitch the role as a route to becoming an adviser; the JD is explicit that you continue in the Wealth Management division.

B3. How the role connects to the business model

Every head-office project should move one of SJP's profit levers (see A4). If you can say which lever your work moves, you sound commercial.

Head-office lever	Business metric it moves	Why it matters now
Better adviser tools, less admin	**Adviser productivity → gross inflows**	SJP is trialling AI tools for Partners (PRIMARY). Investors fear AI disruption (REPORTED, Feb 2026)
Proposition for retirement and IHT	**Gross inflows, retention**	Pensions are 55% of FUM. Pensions enter IHT from April 2027
Evidencing reviews, Consumer Duty MI	**Avoids remediation, protects margin and reputation**	The refund provision started at £426m (PRIMARY)
Client experience, complaints insight	**Retention (~95%)**	Each 1 point of retention is worth ~£2.4bn of FUM a year (derived)
Partner recruitment and growth	**Distribution capacity**	Adviser headcount is roughly flat at ~4,950 (PRIMARY)
Simplification and efficiency	**Costs**	~£100m savings target by 2027 (PRIMARY)
Strategy work in the CEO Office	**Net flows**, the "Amplify" phase from 2027	Net inflows slowed to £0.57bn in Q3 2026 (REPORTED)

One line for the interview [Interpretation]:

> "SJP's profit is FUM times margin, and FUM grows through the Partners. The Wealth Management function is where SJP makes its Partners more productive and its advice more provably good, which drives inflows and retention and protects the margin. That's why I want to work there."

B4. What they're looking for, and how to show it

JD wants	How to evidence it in a 1–2 minute video answer
Communication and relationship-building	An example of explaining something complex simply, or of winning someone round
Analytical and problem-solving ability	A specific dataset or problem: what you found, what you recommended, and the result in numbers
Comfort with data and presenting findings	Name the tool (Excel, Python, Power BI) and the audience you presented to
Initiative, adaptability, willingness to learn	Something you started without being asked; or a fast change you handled
Managing competing priorities	Exams plus a job or society role: how you prioritised
Genuine interest in financial planning and client outcomes	Your knowledge of SJP (this pack) plus *why* advice matters to you personally

Five smart questions to ask at later stages

1. "Which teams do graduates typically rotate through, and how is the rotation chosen?"

2. "How is the Wealth Management function's success measured: adviser productivity, retention, client outcomes?"
3. "How is SJP using AI and technology to free up Partners' time, and where do graduates contribute?"
4. "What will the move from 'Strengthen' to 'Amplify' mean for the Wealth Management division in 2027?"
5. "How does the Level 4 study fit around the rotations?"

Glossary

Term	Meaning
AME	SJP's Asia and Middle East business
Basis point (bp)	0.01%. 45bps = 0.45%
Capacity for loss	How much a client could lose without damaging their plans
Cashflow modelling	Projecting a client's finances year by year to test plans
D2C	Direct-to-consumer: investors use a platform themselves, without an adviser
DFM	Discretionary fund management: a manager makes the investment decisions for the client
Drawdown	Keeping a pension invested and taking income from it in retirement
FUM	Funds under management: total client money looked after
Gestation	Under SJP's old charges, the first six years of pension and bond money, when it earned little product margin
Gross / net inflows	New money in / new money in minus money out
HNW / UHNW	High net worth / ultra-high net worth (conventionally US$30m+)
MI	Management information: regular data reports for decision-makers
Partner	SJP's self-employed adviser, an appointed representative of SJP
Polaris	SJP's flagship multi-asset fund range
Restricted advice	Advice limited to certain products or providers (vs independent, whole-of-market)
Retention	Share of client money that didn't leave in the period
Suitability report	The written explanation of why advice fits the client
Wrapper	The tax structure money sits in: pension, ISA, bond, unit trust

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Sources

- SJP Full Year Results 2025, press release (PDF): FUM by product, flows, cash result, gestation, asset mix
- SJP Half Year Report 2026: clients, advisers, FUM
- SJP charging structure announcement
- SJP: Other services (Partnership site) and SJP products and services: service range
- TheWealthNet: SJP appoints wealth management CEO: James Rainbow
- Yahoo Finance: SJP names Justin Onuekwusi CEO of investments

- FCA: Advice Guidance Boundary Review
- The job description you provided (Wealth Management Graduate Programme, closes 16 Oct 2026).